CONCLUSION

For many years after 9/11 the US did not push Pakistan on Lashkar, instead focusing mainly on eliciting support for the fight against al-Qaeda. That changed after the Mumbai attacks and since then concerns about the group have grown in concert with its expansion in Afghanistan and the wider South Asian region. Approximately one year after Mumbai, US President Barack Obama wrote a letter to his Pakistani counterpart, President Asif Ali Zardari, in which he specifically mentioned Lashkar as one of the militant groups against which the government should act.[1] A chorus of US diplomats, security officials and military officers reiterated this call for action, pressuring Pakistan publicly as well as privately to move against Lashkar. Yet the group's position remains relatively secure. There are two main reasons for this state of affairs. First, despite collaboration with other actors waging war against state and the involvement of some of its members in anti-state violence, Lashkar's policy remains to abjure launching attacks in Pakistan. The security establishment has determined that in order to avoid additional instability it must not take any action that could lead Lashkar to change this position. Second, the group still provides much needed leverage vis-à-vis India. The civilian government is more amenable to cracking down on militant outfits that provide utility against India, but has no real control over the army or ISI, which continue to determine the country's policies in this regard. Thus, while Pakistan has made efforts to battle some of the militant groups operating from its soil, selectivity with regard to which outfits to take action against remains the order of the day. A former high-ranking ISI officer put it bluntly, saying, 'Pakistan is being expected to hit Lashkar to prove we are treating every jihadi group equally when it is other groups that are hitting us while Lashkar is not.' For this reason, he said 'they are not equal to us and of course Pakistan favors Lashkar.'[2]